(Turkey, Saudi Arabia, or Qatar) where they can talk to the government Afghan-to-Afghan without Pakistan looking over their shoulders. The Taliban's office in Doha, which hosted many members of the Quetta shura, was an exercise to this effect. In this setting the Karzai administration was willing to give them some things they wanted, which were security, immunity, and livelihood. On the other hand, the Western model was understood as having little to do with Afghanistan's interests. It had more to do with Western interests in which 'they' present 'themselves' as the saviours of peace and exit from Afghanistan. In that scenario, if talks broke down at a later stage, then the West can say that they gave the Afghans a good 'present but they [Afghans] squabbled amongst themselves and tore it up,' he argued.[118] India was skeptical about either of the two models succeeding, but favoured the Afghan model over the Western one.

Ludin was surprised by India's pushback on the roadmap. 'Gautam [Mukhopadhaya] argued with me [and] said, "I am sorry but then you're wrong about this thing [roadmap], the whole timeline [of transition of Taliban to a political entity] and elections"'. In February 2013, soon after the Chantilly process and the leaking of the Roadmap, Afghan and Pakistani officials met for the UK-Afghanistan-Pakistan trilateral. Ludin was hoping that his political gamble would pay off and Pakistan would cooperate in intensifying the peace process (at least in stopping the Taliban from disrupting the 2014 elections). As Mukhopadhaya had warned him, nothing came out of it. 'We realised after the London trilateral in early February that the Indian analysis was right' conceded Ludin.[119] Convincing the Taliban not to disrupt the elections, and to become a political party was too ambitious a plan. Especially 'when everything really hinges on Pakistan, then it is not something that is in my control, in India's control, or even in America's control. I think if any country that plays a big role is Pakistan', he argued.[120] But Pakistan was unwilling and/or unable to deliver. By 2013 all hope faded for reconciliation to proceed either on Afghan terms or those set by Pakistan. Washington had decided to wrap up its mission by the end of 2014 and initiated an independent dialogue with the Afghan Taliban, incensing both Kabul and Islamabad.

## *Persian disconnect*